ROOT CAUSE UNLOCKED

The Complete Patient's Guide to Tennis *Elbow*

Natural Strategies for Lateral Epicondylitis Relief, Healing, and Recovery

Dr. Adam Seay, DC

Root Cause Unlocked, Garner, NC · rootcauseunlocked.com · (919) 662-0520

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BEFORE YOU START

> ***Disclaimer:*** *This ebook is for educational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Always consult with a qualified healthcare provider before starting any new treatment, supplement, exercise program, or dietary change. Never start, stop, or change a prescribed medication without talking to the prescriber first. If you experience progressive weakness, severe swelling, fever, or symptoms that worsen rapidly, seek medical attention immediately.*
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> ***A note on the evidence in this guide.*** *Every numbered citation in this book has been checked against the published record. Where the research studied a different tissue, a different joint, or a different population than tennis elbow, that is stated plainly in the text so you can judge the strength of the evidence yourself. Where a popular claim had no supporting study behind it, the claim was removed rather than dressed up.*

Contents

1. What Is Tennis Elbow?

Tennis elbow, medically known as lateral epicondylitis (or more accurately, lateral epicondylosis or lateral epicondylar tendinopathy), is a painful condition affecting the tendons on the outside of your elbow. Despite the name, most people who develop it are not tennis players. It shows up far more often in workers and in people whose daily tasks involve repeated gripping.

The condition involves the extensor carpi radialis brevis (ECRB) tendon and other forearm extensor tendons that attach to the lateral epicondyle, the bony bump on the outside of your elbow. These tendons are responsible for extending your wrist and fingers.

Common Symptoms

The most common symptom is pain or burning on the outer part of the elbow, often radiating down the forearm toward the wrist. Many people notice weakness in grip strength, showing up as difficulty shaking hands, turning a doorknob, or holding a coffee cup. Pain typically worsens with wrist extension, gripping, or lifting, especially when the palm faces down. Stiffness in the elbow is common, particularly in the morning, along with tenderness to touch directly over the lateral epicondyle.

Important distinction: Tennis elbow affects the outside of the elbow. Pain on the inside of the elbow is called golfer’s elbow (medial epicondylitis) and involves different tendons.

2. Understanding the Anatomy

The lateral epicondyle is the bony prominence on the outer side of your elbow. It serves as the attachment point for the common extensor tendon, which branches into several muscles. The extensor carpi radialis brevis (ECRB) is the primary tendon involved in tennis elbow. The extensor digitorum communis extends the fingers, the extensor carpi radialis longus extends and abducts the wrist, the extensor digiti minimi extends the little finger, and the extensor carpi ulnaris extends and adducts the wrist.

These muscles work together to extend your wrist and fingers, stabilize your wrist during gripping activities, and absorb forces transmitted from the hand and wrist up the arm.

Why the ECRB Is Vulnerable

The ECRB tendon has a relatively poor blood supply compared to other tendons in the body. It also passes over the rounded head of the radius bone, creating friction with every wrist and elbow movement. This combination of limited blood supply and mechanical stress makes it particularly susceptible to overuse injury.

3. Common Causes and Risk Factors

What Actually Happens in the Tendon

Tennis elbow is not primarily an inflammatory condition. It is a tendinopathy. Tissue taken from the affected tendon during surgery shows a characteristic degenerative picture rather than an inflammatory one[1]. That picture includes angiofibroblastic hyperplasia, an abnormal growth of blood vessels and fibroblasts, along with disorganized collagen fibers that lose the normal parallel alignment and become haphazard. The ground substance, the gel-like matrix between collagen fibers, becomes excessive, and inflammatory cells are largely absent, unlike true "-itis" conditions where they would be expected.

This is why the terms "tendinosis" and "tendinopathy" are now preferred over "tendinitis." The problem is tissue degeneration and failed healing, not active inflammation[1].

Primary Causes

The most common cause is repetitive wrist extension and gripping, where repeated microtrauma exceeds the tendon's capacity to repair itself. A sudden increase in activity, such as starting a new sport, job, or hobby that involves repetitive forearm use, can also trigger the condition, as can poor technique or ergonomics, meaning incorrect form in sports or an improper workstation setup. Age-related tendon change plays a role too, since tendons lose elasticity and blood supply with age.

Risk Factors

Occupation. This is the best-documented risk factor. A population-based case-referent study of 267 new tennis elbow cases found that manual job tasks roughly tripled the odds of developing the condition, and that a combined index of forceful work, non-neutral hand and arm posture, and repetition showed a clear dose response: the odds rose about fourfold at the highest strain level[2]. A review of the occupational literature reaches the same conclusion, that force, repetition, and awkward posture are the dominant work-related drivers[3]. Occupations commonly affected include plumbers, carpenters, painters, and mechanics; assembly line workers, butchers, and chefs; office workers with poor keyboard and mouse ergonomics; and musicians, especially string players and pianists.

Age. Tennis elbow is most common in middle age. A large general-population survey of upper-limb musculoskeletal disorders found lateral epicondylitis clustering in the middle adult years rather than in the young or the elderly[4].

Sports. Tennis (especially backhand strokes), squash, badminton, weightlifting, rowing, and fencing all involve repeated gripping and forearm loading.

Other factors commonly discussed. Smoking, obesity, diabetes, metabolic syndrome, and inherited differences in collagen structure are all raised in the tendon literature as plausible contributors to slower tendon healing. The evidence linking each of them specifically to tennis elbow is thinner than the occupational evidence, so treat them as reasonable general health considerations rather than proven causes of this particular condition.

Psychosocial factors. In the Danish case-referent study, low social support at work was an independent risk factor among women even after adjusting for physical strain[2]. Stress and job strain are not imaginary contributors.

4. How Tennis Elbow Is Diagnosed

Tennis elbow is primarily a clinical diagnosis. Imaging is usually not necessary unless the diagnosis is uncertain or symptoms are not improving with conservative care[5].

Clinical Examination

Palpation: tenderness directly over the lateral epicondyle and just distal to it, especially over the ECRB tendon.

Special tests: In Cozen's test (resisted wrist extension), the patient extends the wrist against resistance with the elbow extended, and pain over the lateral epicondyle indicates a positive test. In Mill's test, the examiner passively flexes the patient's wrist while extending the elbow and pronating the forearm (turning the palm down), and pain at the lateral epicondyle is positive. Maudsley's test involves the examiner applying resistance to middle finger extension, with pain at the lateral epicondyle suggesting ECRB involvement. In the chair test, the patient attempts to lift a chair by the back with the palm facing down and the elbow extended, and pain indicates tennis elbow.

Strength testing typically includes pain-free grip strength measurement, which is often reduced on the affected side and is the most commonly used objective outcome measure in the research[5], along with wrist extensor strength testing.

Imaging (When Needed)

Ultrasound can visualize tendon thickening, hypoechoic (darker) areas indicating degeneration, calcifications, and tears, and is useful for guiding injections. MRI provides detailed images of tendon structure, can detect partial tears, and helps rule out other conditions, though it is usually reserved for stubborn cases or pre-surgical planning. X-rays are generally not helpful for tennis elbow itself, but may be used to rule out arthritis, loose bodies, or calcification.

Differential Diagnosis

Your healthcare provider will also consider other conditions that can mimic tennis elbow. Radial tunnel syndrome involves compression of the radial nerve, causing similar pain but typically more diffuse and without point tenderness. Posterior interosseous nerve (PIN) syndrome, a branch of the radial nerve, is another possibility, as is cervical radiculopathy, nerve root compression in the neck that causes referred arm pain. Elbow arthritis (degenerative changes in the elbow joint) and lateral collateral ligament injury (ligament instability) are also considered, and, though rare, tumor or infection must be ruled out in atypical presentations.

5. The Healing Timeline: What to Expect

Understanding the natural course of tennis elbow helps set realistic expectations and prevents premature escalation to invasive treatments.

Natural History

In the acute phase, the first 0 to 6 weeks, pain is most noticeable, and many people self-treat or modify activities. The subacute phase, from 6 weeks to 6 months, is where structured rehabilitation matters most, though pain may fluctuate. If symptoms persist beyond 6 months, the condition is considered chronic, and more intensive or interventional treatments may be considered.

What the Trials Actually Show

Two of the most important randomized trials in this field compared active treatment against simply waiting.

In a Dutch trial of 185 patients, corticosteroid injection was clearly the best option at 6 weeks. By 52 weeks the picture had reversed: the injection group had the worst outcomes, and physiotherapy and a wait-and-see policy had converged. The authors concluded that the relative gain of physiotherapy over waiting was small, and that patients should be told the trade-offs before choosing[6].

An Australian trial of 198 patients found the same short-term-versus-long-term reversal. Corticosteroid injection won at 6 weeks and lost by 52 weeks, with high recurrence. Physiotherapy (mobilisation with movement plus exercise) outperformed waiting in the first 6 weeks and reduced the need for additional treatment, and by one year the physiotherapy and wait-and-see groups were similar[7].

The practical takeaway: most people improve substantially within a year regardless of what they do, structured exercise gets you there more comfortably, and a fast fix that looks impressive at 6 weeks can leave you worse off at 12 months. Recurrence is common if the underlying load and biomechanical issues are not addressed.

6. Supplements for Tendon Healing and Inflammation

Read this section carefully. The supplements below are grouped by how strong the evidence actually is. Almost none of them have been tested in people with tennis elbow specifically. Most of the research is in knee osteoarthritis, general wound healing, or laboratory models. That does not make them useless, but it does mean the honest claim is “biologically plausible and reasonably safe,” not “proven to heal your elbow.”

Always discuss supplements with your healthcare provider, especially if you take medications. Several of the items below can interact with blood thinners.

6.1 Collagen / Gelatin plus Vitamin C

What it does: provides the building blocks (the amino acids glycine, proline, and hydroxyproline) for tendon collagen synthesis. Vitamin C is a required cofactor for collagen cross-linking and stability.

Evidence: In a controlled crossover study in healthy young men, taking 15 g of vitamin C-enriched gelatin one hour before a short bout of rope-skipping doubled the blood level of PINP, a marker of new collagen formation, compared with placebo. In the same study, engineered ligaments grown in the laboratory and bathed in serum drawn from those subjects after supplementation showed increased collagen content and improved mechanical strength[8]. The subjects were healthy volunteers and the outcome was a laboratory marker, not a clinical trial in people with tendon pain.

Two longer studies in the broader connective-tissue literature are worth knowing. A 24-week randomized trial in athletes with activity-related joint pain reported reduced joint pain with collagen hydrolysate[9]. A meta-analysis of randomized placebo-controlled trials found collagen supplementation improved symptom scores in osteoarthritis[10]. Both of those trials were conducted in joint disease, and neither one touched tennis elbow.

Typical dosage: 10 to 15 g hydrolyzed collagen or gelatin daily, with roughly 50 mg vitamin C The lower end of that range is the dose used in a randomized trial of collagen peptides in active adults.[47] **Timing:** 30 to 60 minutes before your loading exercises, mirroring the study protocol **Best form:** hydrolyzed collagen peptides (dissolve easily, well absorbed) **Caution:** generally very safe. Source quality matters.

6.2 Vitamin C

What it does: essential cofactor for collagen synthesis, an antioxidant that protects cells from oxidative stress, and a supporter of immune function.

Evidence: Vitamin C deficiency causes scurvy, characterized by defective collagen and tissue fragility. This is settled physiology. A 2018 systematic review looking specifically at vitamin C after musculoskeletal injury found only ten eligible articles, and the tendon-healing findings came from animal studies that reported increased type I collagen and scar tissue formation with supplementation[11]. No human clinical trial has yet established that supplementing vitamin C speeds tendon repair.

Typical dosage: 500 to 1,000 mg daily The lower end of that range is a dose arm from the randomized dose-response trial of vitamin C after wrist fracture.[46] **Best form:** ascorbic acid or buffered forms (calcium or magnesium ascorbate) **Caution:** high doses can cause digestive upset. Split doses through the day.

6.3 Omega-3 Fatty Acids (EPA/DHA)

What it does: EPA and DHA are incorporated into cell membranes and are precursors to specialized pro-resolving mediators (resolvins and protectins), signaling molecules that actively switch off an inflammatory response rather than merely blocking it.

Evidence: The mechanism above is well described in a review of how omega-3 fatty acids act on inflammatory processes, from the molecular level up[12]. That review makes the case for biological plausibility, but it is not a pain trial, and omega-3 supplementation has never been put to the test in tennis elbow.

Typical dosage: 1,200 to 2,400 mg combined EPA and DHA daily. That is the range used in the one study run in people with nonsurgical neck and back pain, where most participants took 1,200 mg daily and about a fifth took 2,400 mg. That study was an uncontrolled questionnaire follow-up rather than a placebo-controlled trial, so treat it as a starting point rather than a proven dose. Higher intakes appear in the joint-pain literature, but that work was done in rheumatoid arthritis and other inflammatory conditions rather than in the mechanical and degenerative problems this guide covers, so I have not carried its dose across.[48] **Best form:** triglyceride or re-esterified triglyceride form **Caution:** may increase bleeding risk at higher doses. Tell your surgeon before any procedure.

6.4 Turmeric / Curcumin

What it does: curcumin inhibits NF-kappa-B, a master regulator of inflammatory gene expression, and several inflammatory enzymes.

Evidence: A systematic review and meta-analysis of randomized trials found that turmeric extract at roughly 1,000 mg per day of curcumin improved arthritis symptoms. The authors were explicit about the limits of their own finding: the number of trials, the total sample size, and the methodological quality were not sufficient to draw definitive conclusions, and larger rigorous studies are needed[13]. Present that caveat to anyone who quotes curcumin research at you.

Typical dosage: 500 to 1,000 mg curcuminoids daily, preferably with piperine (black pepper extract) or in a liposomal or phytosome form **Caution:** may interact with blood thinners. Avoid in gallbladder disease.

6.5 Vitamin D

What it does: essential for musculoskeletal health and involved in muscle function and inflammatory regulation.

Evidence: A well-known clinic study of 150 patients presenting with persistent, nonspecific musculoskeletal pain found that a striking proportion had severe vitamin D deficiency[14]. Note what this study is and is not: it measured how common deficiency was in that group, not whether correcting it relieves pain, since it was not a supplementation trial. There is, in fact, no credible study tying vitamin D status specifically to tennis elbow.

The reasonable position: if you have persistent musculoskeletal pain, having your level checked is sensible, and correcting a genuine deficiency is good general medicine.

Typical dosage: based on your blood level, discussed with your provider. Commonly 2,000 to 5,000 IU daily when correcting a low level. **Best form:** D3 (cholecalciferol) **Caution:** have levels rechecked. Toxicity is rare but real at very high sustained doses.

6.6 Magnesium

What it does: required for hundreds of enzyme reactions including ATP production, and involved in normal muscle contraction and relaxation.

Evidence: A systematic review of randomized controlled trials of magnesium for chronic pain in adults located only nine eligible trials and concluded that the evidence was equivocal, while noting efficacy signals in some trials that justify better-designed future studies[15]. In other words: plausible, popular, not proven.

Typical dosage: 200 to 400 mg elemental magnesium daily. Glycinate is well tolerated. This is a general supplemental intake range rather than a dose drawn from a trial in this condition, which is why no study is cited beside it. **Caution:** can cause diarrhea, particularly the oxide and citrate forms. Avoid in severe kidney disease.

6.7 Zinc

What it does: zinc-dependent enzymes are involved in collagen synthesis, tissue remodeling, and immune function.

Evidence: A review of zinc physiology and clinical applications states the position clearly: there is consensus that zinc deficiency impairs wound healing, but considerable disagreement in the literature about the optimal method and the true benefit of zinc supplementation in people who are not deficient[16].

Typical dosage: 15 to 30 mg elemental zinc daily (picolinate or bisglycinate). This is a general supplemental intake range rather than a dose drawn from a trial in this condition. It sits above ordinary dietary intake and below the tolerable upper limit, which is why the copper caution below matters. **Caution:** long-term high-dose zinc can cause copper deficiency. Do not exceed 40 mg daily without medical supervision.

6.8 Boswellia Serrata (Frankincense)

What it does: inhibits 5-lipoxygenase (5-LOX), an enzyme in the inflammatory cascade, and reduces leukotriene production.

Evidence: A systematic review and meta-analysis of randomized trials in **osteoarthritis** patients concluded that Boswellia and its extract may be an effective and safe option, and that treatment should run for at least 4 weeks to see an effect[17]. The population studied was osteoarthritis; Boswellia has not been trialed in tennis elbow.

Typical dosage: 300 to 500 mg standardized extract (AKBA content) twice daily **Caution:** may interact with anti-inflammatory medications.

6.9 Methylsulfonylmethane (MSM)

What it does: an organic sulfur compound. Sulfur participates in the disulfide bonds that stabilize connective tissue proteins.

Evidence: A pilot randomized trial in **knee osteoarthritis** found that MSM at 3 g twice daily produced significant reductions in WOMAC pain and physical function impairment compared with placebo over a short intervention, with no major adverse events. The investigators themselves called for larger trials before drawing firm conclusions[18]. A later double-blind randomized trial in grade I to II **knee osteoarthritis** found that adding MSM to glucosamine-chondroitin sulfate produced significantly better WOMAC and pain scores at 12 weeks than glucosamine-chondroitin alone or placebo[19].

Both of these are knee osteoarthritis trials, and neither one tells you anything about tendons or elbows.

Typical dosage: 1,500 to 3,000 mg daily **Caution:** generally well tolerated. Minor digestive upset in some people.

6.10 Proteolytic Enzymes (Bromelain, Serrapeptase)

What it does: proteolytic enzymes taken between meals are proposed to act systemically on inflammatory proteins.

Evidence: A review of bromelain describes its documented properties and the range of clinical uses that have been explored, including soft tissue and surgical trauma, wound debridement, and osteoarthritis symptoms[20]. That review simply describes the compound; it is not a trial demonstrating benefit in tendinopathy.

Serrapeptase is widely sold and has a long history of use in Europe and Asia, but there are no controlled trials supporting it for tennis elbow. If you use it, use it knowing that.

Typical dosage: bromelain 500 to 1,000 mg (2,000 to 4,000 GDU) daily between meals; serrapeptase 60,000 to 120,000 SPU daily on an empty stomach **Caution:** may interact with blood thinners. Take away from meals for a systemic rather than digestive effect.

6.11 Hyaluronic Acid

What it does: hyaluronic acid is a genuine component of the extracellular matrix around tendons, contributing to gliding and lubrication.

Evidence, stated honestly: A literature review of hyaluronic acid in tendon lesions found encouraging preclinical results, in the laboratory and in animals, showing that HA improves tendon gliding, reduces adhesions, improves architectural organization, and limits inflammation. The clinical results were described as limited but encouraging short-term effects on pain and function, and the authors concluded that controlled randomized studies are still needed[21].

Two things follow. First, that evidence concerns hyaluronic acid **injected** by a clinician, not an oral supplement. Second, nothing shows that oral hyaluronic acid capsules reach an injured tendon or do it any good. This guide does not recommend oral hyaluronic acid for tennis elbow. It is listed here so that you recognize the marketing claim when you meet it and know exactly how thin the support is.

7. Targeted Exercises for Tennis Elbow Relief

Critical rule: Exercises for tennis elbow should be performed slowly and with control. Mild discomfort (2 to 3 out of 10) during exercise is acceptable, but sharp pain, or increased pain lasting more than 24 hours after exercise, means you need to reduce intensity or volume.

7.1 Isometric Wrist Extension

Best for: early-stage rehabilitation when even movement causes pain

How to perform: 1. Sit with your forearm supported on a table, wrist hanging over the edge, palm facing down 2. Place your unaffected hand on top of the back of your affected hand 3. Try to lift the back of your hand up while resisting with your other hand 4. Hold the contraction for 30 to 45 seconds 5. Perform 3 to 5 repetitions, 2 to 3 times daily

Why it works: Isometric contractions load the tendon without joint movement, which many people tolerate when movement hurts. The best-known study of this effect was performed in athletes with **patellar tendinopathy**, where a single bout of isometric contractions produced immediate and sustained pain reduction and reduced cortical inhibition of the quadriceps[22]. That study was in the knee, not the elbow. The principle has been widely adopted in upper-limb rehabilitation, but the direct elbow evidence is weaker than the popularity of the technique suggests.

7.2 Eccentric Wrist Extension

Best for: the cornerstone of tennis elbow rehabilitation

How to perform: 1. Sit with your forearm supported, palm facing down, holding a light weight (1 to 3 lbs) or a resistance band 2. Use your unaffected hand to lift the weight up (concentric phase) 3. Slowly lower the weight over a count of 3 to 4 seconds (eccentric phase) 4. Perform 3 sets of 10 to 15 repetitions 5. Progress the weight gradually as tolerated

Why it works: Eccentric loading, lengthening the muscle-tendon unit under tension, stimulates collagen remodeling and promotes proper fiber alignment. The landmark trial establishing heavy slow eccentric loading was conducted in **Achilles tendinopathy**, where the eccentric group returned to running while the control group did not[23]. That is Achilles evidence extrapolated to the elbow, and this guide states that plainly rather than pretending otherwise.

For the elbow itself, a systematic review of twelve studies of eccentric exercise in lateral epicondylitis found that every group whose program included eccentric exercise reported decreased pain and improved function and grip strength from baseline, with seven studies reporting improvements for treatment packages that included eccentric work[24]. Most of those programs combined eccentrics with other treatments, so eccentric loading is best described as a well-supported component of care rather than a proven stand-alone cure.

Progression: start with 1 lb and increase by 0.5 to 1 lb weekly as long as pain remains acceptable.

7.3 Tyler Twist (FlexBar Exercise)

Best for: moderate to advanced rehabilitation, and one of the few tennis elbow exercises with a dedicated trial

How to perform: 1. Hold a flexible rubber bar vertically in front of you 2. Grip the top of the bar with the affected arm, wrist extended 3. Grip the bottom with the unaffected arm, wrist flexed 4. Slowly rotate the bar by flexing the unaffected wrist while resisting with the affected wrist 5. Hold the fully twisted position for 2 seconds 6. Slowly return to the starting position 7. Perform 3 sets of 10 to 15 repetitions

Why it works: The movement isolates an eccentric load on the wrist extensors. In a prospective randomized trial, adding this isolated wrist extensor eccentric exercise to standard physical therapy for chronic lateral epicondylosis produced greater improvement than standard therapy alone[25]. This is one of the more directly applicable pieces of evidence in the whole guide.

7.4 Wrist Flexor Stretching

Best for: reducing tension in the opposing muscle group and improving forearm flexibility

How to perform: 1. Extend your affected arm straight out with the palm facing up 2. Use your other hand to gently bend the wrist down, palm toward the floor 3. You should feel a stretch along the flexor side of the forearm 4. Hold for 30 seconds, repeat 3 times 5. Do this 2 to 3 times daily

Why it works: This is general rehabilitation practice rather than a specifically studied intervention. Stretching the flexors is comfortable for most people, improves range of motion, and is low risk.

7.5 Forearm Pronation and Supination

Best for: restoring full forearm rotation

How to perform: 1. Sit with your elbow bent at 90 degrees, tucked at your side 2. Hold a light hammer or small dumbbell vertically 3. Slowly rotate your forearm so the palm faces up (supination), then down (pronation) 4. Perform 2 to 3 sets of 10 to 15 repetitions 5. Keep the movement slow and controlled

Why it works: The forearm extensors are active during rotation as well as wrist extension. Restoring comfortable, controlled rotation is a normal part of returning to work and sport. This is standard practice, not a separately proven treatment.

7.6 Scapular Stabilization

Best for: addressing the wider kinetic chain

Scapular retraction: 1. Sit or stand with good posture 2. Squeeze your shoulder blades together and down, as if tucking them into your back pockets 3. Hold for 5 seconds, repeat 10 times

Wall angels: 1. Stand with your back against a wall, arms in a “W” position 2. Slowly slide your arms up into a “Y” position, keeping contact with the wall 3. Return to “W” 4. Perform 8 to 10 repetitions

Why it is included, and what the evidence really shows: A controlled study comparing people with lateral epicondylalgia to healthy controls found that the involved side had significantly lower middle trapezius, serratus anterior, and lower trapezius strength, lower endurance, and reduced serratus anterior thickness change. The authors were careful to note that some of the differences between the involved and uninvolved arms were small and of potentially limited clinical relevance[26].

Read that precisely. It shows an **association** between scapular muscle performance and lateral epicondylalgia. It does not show that scapular exercises improve tennis elbow outcomes. No trial has demonstrated that. These exercises are included here as sensible general conditioning that costs nothing, carries essentially no risk, and addresses a measurable deficit, not as an evidence-backed treatment for elbow pain.

7.7 Grip Strengthening

Best for: restoring functional grip strength once pain has decreased

How to perform: 1. Squeeze a soft stress ball or therapy putty 2. Hold for 5 seconds, release 3. Perform 10 to 15 repetitions 4. Progress to firmer resistance as tolerated

Why it works: Pain-free grip strength is the standard functional measure used to track recovery in the research[5]. Rebuilding it is both the goal and the yardstick. Add this late, not early.

8. Physical Therapies and What the Evidence Says

8.1 Physical Therapy

Physical therapy is the usual first-line treatment for tennis elbow. A skilled therapist will assess your specific movement patterns and biomechanics, prescribe a progressive loading program, and use manual therapy to improve tissue mobility. They will address contributing factors including posture and ergonomics, educate you on activity modification and technique, and progress you through a structured return-to-activity program.

Evidence: A clinical review of physiotherapy management of lateral epicondylalgia summarizes exercise and manual therapy as the mainstays of conservative care and pain-free grip strength as the key outcome measure[5]. A systematic review of 58 randomized controlled trials of non-surgical treatments concluded that physical therapy and exercise-based approaches are appropriate first-line care, while noting how variable the trial quality is across this literature[27].

For manual therapy specifically, a systematic review and meta-analysis of joint mobilization found a modest pooled effect for mobilization with movement on pain ratings, with a mean effect size of 0.43 (95% CI 0.15 to 0.71)[28]. Modest and real is the accurate description, not dramatic.

The strongest exercise evidence is covered in Chapter 7: eccentric loading[24] and the wrist extensor eccentric program tested by Tyler and colleagues[25].

8.2 Extracorporeal Shockwave Therapy (ESWT)

ESWT delivers acoustic shockwaves to the affected tendon.

Evidence, and it is genuinely mixed. A large randomized trial of 114 patients with chronic lateral epicondylitis found ESWT without local anesthesia significantly better than sham on pain and function[29]. A double-blind randomized controlled trial published three years earlier found no benefit over placebo[30]. A systematic review and meta-analysis pooling 13 randomized trials and 1,035 patients found better pain scores and grip strength with ESWT, while stating explicitly that the limited quality and quantity of the included studies means more high-quality trials are needed[31].

What to expect: typically 3 to 5 sessions spaced 1 to 2 weeks apart. Mild discomfort during treatment is normal. Improvement may take 4 to 8 weeks to appear.

8.3 Low-Level Laser Therapy (LLLT) / Photobiomodulation

LLLT uses specific wavelengths of light with the aim of stimulating cellular activity in the tissue.

Evidence: A systematic review and meta-analysis specific to lateral elbow tendinopathy pooled 13 randomized placebo-controlled trials covering 730 patients and reported benefit, while also detecting publication bias in a negative direction and noting that many of the included patients had already failed other treatments[32]. A broader systematic review across tendinopathies found conflicting results: of 25 controlled trials, 12 showed positive effects and 13 were inconclusive or negative. The authors' key observation was that the positive trials clustered around a particular dosage window, suggesting that dose and technique matter a great deal[33].

Practical reading: LLLT may help if it is delivered at the right dose by someone who knows the protocol. It is not a reliable stand-alone treatment.

What to expect: painless treatment, 10 to 15 minutes per session, 2 to 3 times per week for 4 to 6 weeks.

8.4 Acupuncture and Dry Needling

Acupuncture involves inserting thin needles at specific points. Dry needling targets myofascial trigger points in the forearm muscles.

Evidence: A systematic review of acupuncture for lateral epicondyle pain found that all included studies suggested a benefit, with five of six showing acupuncture superior to a control treatment, and concluded that there is strong evidence for **short-term** relief[34]. The review did not establish long-term benefit, and short-term is the honest claim.

What to expect: 6 to 10 sessions, typically weekly.

8.5 Massage Therapy and Myofascial Release

Therapeutic massage addresses muscle tension and tissue restriction in the forearm extensors.

Evidence: This is the weakest section in the chapter, and it should be. A pilot randomized study of augmented soft tissue mobilization versus natural history in lateral epicondylitis found that both groups improved, and the study was explicitly designed and reported as a feasibility pilot, too small to detect a difference between the treatments. The authors calculated that a proper trial would need 116 participants and called for one[35]. That trial has not been done.

Massage is comfortable, low risk, and may help you tolerate your loading program. There is no good evidence that it changes the course of the condition.

Focus areas: forearm extensor muscles, trigger points in the forearm, scapular and shoulder musculature, and neck muscles if referred pain is a factor.

8.6 Bracing and Orthotics

Counterforce bracing: a strap worn just below the elbow, intended to reduce tension at the ECRB tendon origin.

Evidence: A prospective, randomized, double-blinded, **placebo-controlled** trial compared a counterforce brace against a placebo brace in acute tennis elbow, following patients out to a mean of three years. Both braces improved pain and function. The counterforce brace produced significantly greater reduction in pain frequency and severity in the short term (2 to 12 weeks) and better overall elbow function at 26 weeks compared with the placebo brace[36]. This is a properly controlled trial with a modest, real, mostly short-term benefit. That is a fair reason to use a brace during aggravating activities and not a reason to expect it to cure anything.

Wrist splinting: immobilizing the wrist (not the elbow) in a neutral position reduces strain on the extensor tendons during provoking tasks.

What to expect: braces are most helpful during aggravating activities. They should not be worn around the clock, since prolonged immobilization leads to stiffness and weakness.

8.7 Platelet-Rich Plasma (PRP) Injections

PRP involves drawing your blood, concentrating the platelets, and injecting the concentrate into the affected tendon.

Evidence, and this is a genuinely contested area. A double-blind randomized controlled trial comparing PRP with corticosteroid injection found PRP better at one year[37], and the same cohort followed to two years continued to favor PRP, with success defined as at least a 25% reduction in pain or disability score without reintervention[38].

Against that, a randomized, double-blind, **placebo-controlled** trial comparing PRP, glucocorticoid, and saline injection found no significant difference between PRP and saline[39]. The distinction matters: the first two trials compared PRP against a steroid injection, which we know does poorly in the long run. The third compared PRP against salt water, and PRP did not win.

Considerations: PRP is generally considered only when conservative care has failed for 6 months or more. It is not first-line treatment, it is usually not covered by insurance, and the evidence does not currently support paying for it as an early option.

8.8 Corticosteroid Injections

Corticosteroids are potent anti-inflammatory agents injected into the painful area.

Evidence: A systematic review of randomized controlled trials of injection therapies for tendinopathy found that despite the effectiveness of corticosteroid injections in the short term, the long-term picture is unfavorable for lateral epicondylalgia, and that non-corticosteroid injections may be preferable for longer-term treatment. The authors also cautioned that findings should not be generalized across different tendinopathy sites[40]. Note that this is a systematic review, not a single study, though it is often described as one.

The individual randomized trials tell the same story from the patient's side: excellent relief at 6 weeks, the worst outcomes of any group at 52 weeks, and high recurrence[6,7].

The verdict: a corticosteroid injection may offer meaningful short-term relief for severe pain, and there are situations where that is the right call. It should be used cautiously, not repeatedly, and not as a substitute for a loading program. Discuss the 6-week versus 12-month trade-off explicitly with your provider before agreeing to one.

8.9 Surgery

Surgery for tennis elbow involves releasing or debriding the degenerated tendon tissue. It is considered only after 6 to 12 months of genuinely failed conservative treatment.

Evidence: A systematic review of surgical treatment for lateral epicondylitis found the literature too thin and too heterogeneous to support a meta-analysis. No technique appeared superior by any measure, and the authors concluded that until randomized controlled trials are performed it is reasonable to defer to the individual surgeon's experience[41].

A caution worth taking seriously. Orthopedic surgery has a documented history of procedures that looked highly successful in uncontrolled series and then failed when tested against a sham operation. The clearest example is arthroscopic surgery for knee osteoarthritis: in a controlled trial where patients were randomly assigned to debridement, lavage, or a placebo procedure, outcomes after the real operations were no better than after the placebo[42]. That trial was about the knee, not the elbow, and it does not prove anything about elbow surgery. It is a general lesson about why "most of my patients got better after the operation" is not the same as "the operation works," and it is a fair question to raise with any surgeon proposing an elective tendon procedure.

Considerations: surgery is rarely necessary. Exhaust conservative options first.

9. The Anti-Inflammatory Diet for Tendon Recovery

While tennis elbow is a degenerative tendinopathy rather than a true inflammatory condition, nutrition supports tissue repair and collagen synthesis in general. The recommendations in this chapter are ordinary good nutrition applied to a healing tissue. They are not presented as a treatment for tennis elbow, and no diet has been tested as a treatment for this condition.

9.1 Foods to Emphasize

Collagen-supporting foods: bone broth (rich in glycine and proline), chicken and fish skin, egg whites, citrus fruits and berries for vitamin C

Omega-3 rich foods: wild-caught salmon, sardines, mackerel, anchovies, walnuts, flaxseeds, chia seeds. A reasonable goal is 2 to 3 servings of fatty fish per week.

Colorful vegetables and fruits: leafy greens (spinach, kale, Swiss chard), berries, cruciferous vegetables (broccoli, cauliflower), orange and yellow vegetables (carrots, sweet potatoes). Aim for 8 to 10 servings of vegetables and fruits daily.

Quality protein: grass-fed meats, pasture-raised poultry, wild fish, eggs, legumes if tolerated. The meta-analysis and meta-regression across 49 studies and 1,863 participants found that the benefit of added protein plateaus at roughly 1.6 grams per kilogram of body weight daily, which is about 0.7 grams per pound, or around 130 grams for a 180 pound adult.[45] That is the number worth hitting, and eating past it has not been shown to add anything. Most people rehabbing an injury are well under it, which makes this the cheapest correction in this chapter.

Anti-inflammatory spices: turmeric (with black pepper), ginger, garlic, cinnamon

Healthy fats: extra virgin olive oil, avocados, nuts and seeds

Zinc-rich foods: oysters, beef, pumpkin seeds, lentils

9.2 Foods to Minimize

Pro-inflammatory fats: trans fats (partially hydrogenated oils), excessive omega-6 vegetable oils (corn, soybean, safflower), deep-fried foods

Refined carbohydrates and sugars: white bread, pastries, sugary cereals, soda and sweetened beverages, candy and desserts. Beyond the general metabolic effects, high sugar intake promotes advanced glycation end-products (AGEs), which cross-link collagen.

Processed foods: deli meats, hot dogs, bacon, fast food, packaged snacks

Excessive alcohol: depletes B-vitamins and zinc, impairs protein synthesis, and interferes with sleep, which matters for repair

AGE-rich preparations: heavily charred or high-temperature-grilled meats. AGEs cross-link collagen fibers, making connective tissue stiffer.

9.3 Hydration

Adequate hydration supports nutrient delivery and waste removal.

A simple target: half your body weight in pounds, taken as ounces of water daily. For a 160-pound person that is about 80 ounces, roughly 10 cups.

Tips: start the day with 16 to 20 oz of water, drink before meals, limit caffeine and alcohol, add electrolytes if you sweat heavily.

9.4 Sample Anti-Inflammatory Day

Breakfast: a smoothie with spinach, blueberries, collagen powder, flaxseed, ginger, almond butter, and unsweetened almond milk. Or oatmeal with walnuts, chia seeds, cinnamon, berries, and a scoop of collagen.

Mid-morning snack: apple with almond butter, or a handful of pumpkin seeds

Lunch: a large salad with mixed greens, grilled salmon, avocado, cherry tomatoes, olive oil and lemon dressing. Side of bone broth.

Afternoon snack: carrot and celery sticks with hummus, or hard-boiled eggs

Dinner: grass-fed beef or chicken stew with a bone broth base, turmeric, and garlic. Steamed broccoli and sweet potato. Side salad with olive oil.

Evening (optional): ginger or turmeric tea, and a small square of dark chocolate at 70% cacao or higher

10. Lifestyle Modifications and Pain Management

10.1 Activity Modification

This is the single most important change you can make, and it is supported by the strongest risk-factor evidence in the whole guide. Force, repetition, and awkward wrist and forearm posture are the documented drivers of this condition[2,3]. Reducing them is not a soft recommendation.

Workplace ergonomics: for keyboard and mouse use, choose a mouse that keeps your wrist in a neutral position. A vertical mouse or trackball helps many people, and positioning the keyboard so your elbows are near 90 degrees and your wrists are straight also helps. Take micro-breaks: every 20 to 30 minutes, stop typing and mousing for 30 seconds and stretch your wrists and forearms. Voice-to-text software can reduce repetitive typing where practical, and tool modification, using tools with larger grips, padded handles, or spring-assisted mechanisms, reduces grip force.

Sports modification: tennis players should check racquet grip size, since too small a grip increases strain, consider a more flexible, lighter racquet, and have a professional assess their backhand technique. Weightlifters should avoid the exercises that aggravate symptoms, such as wrist curls, reverse wrist curls, and heavy gripping, and lifting straps can reduce grip demand. All athletes should return gradually, with a common guideline of increasing volume or intensity by no more than about 10% per week.

Household activities: use two hands to lift heavy pots and pans, use a jar opener to reduce grip force, carry grocery bags on your forearm rather than gripping the handles, and use a backpack instead of a briefcase.

10.2 Sleep Optimization

Helpful strategies include maintaining a consistent sleep schedule, keeping your room cool, around 65 to 68 degrees F (18 to 20 C), and limiting screens for an hour before bed. Avoid caffeine after 2 PM, and sleep with the affected arm supported on a pillow to reduce strain.

Evidence: A review of the relationship between sleep and pain concluded that the association runs in both directions, and that sleep disturbance appears to be at least as strong a predictor of subsequent pain as pain is of subsequent sleep disturbance[43]. Sleep is not a nice-to-have in a recovery plan.

10.3 Stress Management

Chronic stress is a plausible contributor to slower recovery, and in the occupational data on tennis elbow, low workplace social support was an independent risk factor among women[2].

Techniques worth trying include diaphragmatic breathing for 5 minutes twice daily, progressive muscle relaxation, meaning systematically tensing and releasing muscle groups, and gentle yoga or tai chi. Mindfulness meditation has better evidence behind it than most: a randomized clinical trial in 342 adults with

chronic low back pain found that mindfulness-based stress reduction improved back pain and functional limitation more than usual care at 26 weeks, and performed comparably to cognitive behavioral therapy[44]. That trial studied low back pain, not tennis elbow. It supports mindfulness as a general chronic pain tool, not as an elbow treatment.

10.4 Smoking Cessation

Smoking reduces peripheral blood flow and impairs oxygen delivery to tissue, and tendon tissue already has a limited blood supply. Stopping smoking is sound general advice for anyone healing a musculoskeletal injury and for many other reasons besides.

You may see a specific figure quoted for smoking and tendon surgery outcomes. I am not going to give you one, because I could not verify a source for it that I would be willing to stand behind. The general point above rests on physiology rather than on a trial, and that is the honest strength of it.

10.5 Weight Management

Maintaining a healthy weight supports overall metabolic health. The link to tennis elbow specifically is weaker than for weight-bearing joints, so treat this as general health advice rather than targeted treatment.

11. The In-Clinic Pre-Treatment Protocol

Understand what this is for, because the distinction matters.

None of this rebuilds tissue. The loading and strengthening work in the previous chapters does that. What this protocol does is reduce the muscle tone, stiffness and tissue sensitivity that make the strength work harder to tolerate and less pleasant to do, particularly in the early weeks when things are at their most irritable.

It is preparation, not treatment. I use it in the clinic before the working part of a session, and I give it to patients to use at home before theirs. Patients who do it tend to tolerate the loading better and stick with it longer, and sticking with it is the actual mechanism by which recovery happens.

If you have to choose between doing this and doing your strength work, do your strength work.

Percussion massager.

- Triceps, round ball or dampener, level 2 to 3, circles, 60 to 90 seconds. Avoid the elbow joint.
- Biceps and brachialis, round ball, level 2, 45 to 60 seconds. Avoid the bicipital groove.
- Forearm flexor mass, dampener or fork, level 1 to 2, linear strokes, 45 to 60 seconds. Light pressure near the medial epicondyle.
- Forearm extensor mass, dampener, level 1 to 2, 45 to 60 seconds.
- Brachioradialis, round ball, level 1 to 2, 30 to 45 seconds.

Massage ball or vibrating sphere.

- Lateral epicondyle region, gentle circles, 60 to 90 seconds, over the extensor tendon origin. Monitor for nerve irritation and stay off the bone.
- Medial epicondyle region, light, 60 to 90 seconds.
- Lateral and medial intermuscular septum, gentle circles along the septum, 60 to 90 seconds.

Firm trigger point tool, linear strokes. Triceps 45 to 60 seconds. Biceps and anterior compartment 45 to 60 seconds. Forearm flexors 30 to 45 seconds. Forearm extensors 30 to 45 seconds. Brachioradialis 30 to 45 seconds.

Additional cautions for the elbow. The ulnar nerve runs superficially at the inside of the elbow, which is the funny bone. No direct pressure on either epicondyle. Stop immediately for tingling or numbness.

Safety, and I mean these.

- Avoid all of this over an acutely injured area in the first 48 to 72 hours.
- Reduce pressure over anything actively inflamed.

- Skip percussion therapy entirely if you have a pacemaker or another implanted electronic device.
- Avoid aggressive pressure over varicose veins or compromised skin.
- Start light. Pain must not exceed 6 out of 10. Back off immediately for sharp or shooting pain.
- Stop and seek advice if you get numbness, tingling, or weakness.
- If you are on a blood thinner, use lighter pressure throughout and check with your prescriber first.

12. Red Flags: When to Seek Immediate Care

Tennis elbow is rarely an emergency, but certain symptoms warrant prompt medical evaluation.

Seek immediate care if you experience:

- Severe swelling, redness, and warmth around the elbow (possible infection)
- Fever with elbow pain
- Sudden, severe pain after a specific injury (possible tendon rupture)
- Inability to extend your wrist or fingers (possible tendon rupture or nerve injury)
- Numbness or tingling in the hand (possible nerve involvement)
- Progressive weakness in the hand or forearm
- A visible deformity or gap in the tendon area

Contact your healthcare provider promptly if:

- Symptoms worsen after 2 to 3 weeks of self-care
- Pain is severe enough to prevent sleep despite rest
- You develop new symptoms such as numbness, tingling, or weakness
- Symptoms persist beyond 6 to 8 weeks without improvement
- You have a history of significant trauma to the elbow
- You have rheumatoid arthritis or another inflammatory condition

13. Building Your Personal Recovery Plan

Use this framework as a starting point for a conversation with your provider, not as a prescription.

Week 1 to 2: Calm and Protect (Acute Phase)

If you choose to use supplements during this phase, collagen plus vitamin C has the most direct mechanistic support for tendon tissue[8]. For movement, rest from aggravating activities and stick to gentle isometric holds and wrist flexor stretches. Therapies at this stage include icing after activity for 15 to 20 minutes, considering a counterforce brace during provoking work tasks[36], and arranging an initial physical therapy evaluation. On the diet side, begin anti-inflammatory eating and increase hydration, and for lifestyle, modify ergonomics, prioritize sleep, and reduce stress load.

Week 3 to 6: Rebuild (Subacute Phase)

Reassess supplements during this phase, adding or dropping them based on how you actually feel and what your provider advises. Movement progresses to eccentric wrist extension, continued isometrics, and added forearm rotation work. Therapies include regular physical therapy, considering acupuncture for short-term pain relief[34], and adding scapular conditioning. Diet moves to the full anti-inflammatory pattern, and lifestyle means implementing the activity modifications properly rather than partially.

Week 7 to 12: Strengthen and Restore

Movement progresses to the FlexBar Tyler Twist[25], with grip strengthening added, resistance increased gradually, and a return to modified activity. Therapies at this stage are maintenance physical therapy visits, and considering shockwave therapy if progress has stalled[29,31]. Diet becomes anti-inflammatory eating as a habit rather than a protocol, and lifestyle means a gradual return to sport and full work duties.

Beyond 12 Weeks: Maintenance and Prevention

Continue eccentric exercises 2 to 3 times per week and maintain the ergonomic changes, since this is where recurrence is prevented. Warm up before demanding activities and address flare-ups early with your established toolkit. Consider injection therapy or surgery only if conservative care has genuinely failed over 6 to 12 months, and only after discussing the long-term trade-offs[40,41].

Final Thoughts

Tennis elbow can be frustratingly persistent. The encouraging news from the randomized trials is that most people improve substantially within a year, and that the improvement happens with conservative care[6,7]. Tendons remodel in response to controlled, progressive loading, and that loading, combined with genuinely reducing the forces that caused the problem, is the core of recovery.

The key is patience and consistency. Tendons are slow to respond because they have a limited blood supply. Pushing too hard too soon often leads to setbacks, and complete rest leads to deconditioning. The working zone is gradual, progressive loading that challenges the tissue without overwhelming it.

Healing is rarely linear. You may have good weeks and frustrating weeks. The goal is steady progress over months, not days. Stay consistent with your exercises and nutrition, and work closely with your healthcare team.

No book can promise you an outcome. What this one can do is tell you which strategies have real evidence behind them, which are plausible but unproven, and which are being sold to you on a claim that does not hold up.

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Working with Root Health

If your elbow has not responded to loading, or you are being offered an injection and want the one-year evidence before you decide, I offer a free Root Discovery Session at Root Health to talk through your options and what a reasonable next step looks like. You can schedule one at rootcauseunlocked.com/discovery, or reach the office at (919) 662-0520.

Consultations and ongoing care are both available wherever you are located. Being outside North Carolina is not a barrier to working with me. Tell me where you are when you reach out and I will lay out exactly how we would work together from there.

If you would rather start on your own, the free Root Cause Unlocked tracker has a mode built for musculoskeletal recovery, at rootcauseunlocked.com/tracker. Eight weeks of it turns “I think it might be helping” into something you and I can both read.

This guide was compiled from peer-reviewed medical literature and clinical best practices. Every citation has been individually verified against the PubMed record. It is intended to give you accurate information and options to discuss with your healthcare provider. It is not a substitute for individual medical care.